Plan 1 · Classic Shimla (toy train) + Manali

Delhi day → overnight Kalka Mail → UNESCO toy train to Shimla, Kufri, Narkanda–Hatu Peak, Manali, Solang, Atal Tunnel–Sissu, Naggar, Jana, Sethan, Kasol–Manikaran. 6 people · Airbnb stays · 24 Dec 2026 – 3 Jan 2027

At a glance

Route	Hyderabad → (12723) → Delhi day → (Kalka Mail) → Kalka → **toy train** → Shimla 2N → (HRTC) → Manali 4N → Kasol day → (bus from Bhuntar) → Delhi → (12724) → Hyderabad
Nights	2 train out (24, 25) · 2 Shimla · 4 Manali · 1 bus · 1 train back
Snow chances	High: Hatu Peak, Solang, Atal Tunnel–Sissu, Sethan. Medium: Kufri, Narkanda. Low: Shimla town
Crowd level	High at Mall Road, Kufri, Solang, Atal Tunnel on 25 Dec and 31 Dec–1 Jan. Low at Hatu, Tani Jubbar, Jana, Sethan, Naggar
Budget per person (6 people)	**≈ ₹23.7k shoestring** (SL, ordinary buses) · **≈ ₹32.3k recommended** (3A on the long trains, Volvo, better Airbnbs)
Temperatures	Shimla −2 to 10 °C · Manali −5 to 7 °C · Sissu/Hatu −10 to −2 °C

What changed for 6 people + toy train

Toy train is in: instead of a Delhi→Shimla bus, you take the overnight Kalka Mail (SL ≈ ₹200) and the 05:20–06:20 toy train (2S ≈ ₹65). That's cheaper than the Volvo, and you sleep on the train instead of paying for a night.

The Delhi gap (07:40–21:10 on 25 Dec) is a sightseeing day: Red Fort, Chandni Chowk, India Gate, Christmas at Sacred Heart.

Costs split 6 ways: one Innova per circuit (≈ ₹750–950 each), 3-bedroom Airbnbs (≈ ₹1,000–2,300 each per night), 3 scooties.

Getting there and back

Hyderabad → Delhi on 24 Dec: board in Hyderabad, Kazipet, Warangal or Vijayawada

Train	Where you board (time)	Reaches Delhi	Runs	Fare / person (SL · 3A)	Use it for
12723 Telangana SF Exp	**Hyderabad Deccan 06:00** · Secunderabad 06:20/06:25 · Kazipet 08:03/08:05	New Delhi ~07:40–08:00 (25 Dec)	Daily	≈ ₹800 · ≈ ₹2,100	**Default.** Cheapest, boards in the city. Delhi day + night train/bus onward
12621 Tamil Nadu SF Exp	Vijayawada 03:50–04:05 · Warangal 06:50/06:52 · **Kazipet 06:55**	New Delhi **06:30** (25 Dec)	Daily	≈ ₹750 · ≈ ₹1,950 (from Kazipet)	**Fast option.** Catches the 07:40 Kalka Shatabdi → Shimla same evening
22691 Bengaluru-Nizamuddin Rajdhani	Secunderabad 07:00/07:10 · Kazipet ~08:50	H. Nizamuddin 05:30	Daily	3A ≈ ₹3,300–4,100 (meals incl.)	Fast and comfortable but ~2× the 3A fare
12625 Kerala SF Exp	Vijayawada ~10:10–10:55 · Warangal ~13:30 · **Kazipet 13:45**	New Delhi 13:30	Daily	≈ ₹750 · ≈ ₹1,950	Backup if 12723 is full (leave Hyderabad by 09:30 by bus)

Getting to Kazipet / Warangal / Vijayawada with 6 people: Kazipet and Warangal are ~140 km (2.5–3 h). TGSRTC buses run through the night from JBS/Uppal to Hanamkonda (≈ ₹200–300), or an Innova one-way ≈ ₹4,000–5,000 (≈ ₹750 pp). Vijayawada is ~275 km (5–6 h). Only worth it if Hyderabad quota is full, because you'd need an overnight bus on 23 Dec.

12723 halts in order (check availability to each): Hyderabad Deccan → Secunderabad → Kazipet → Ramagundam → Mancherial → Sirpur Kagaznagar → Balharshah → Chandrapur → Sevagram → Nagpur → Itarsi → Bhopal → Jhansi → Gwalior → Agra Cantt → New Delhi (~18 halts, ~1,680 km). Confirmed: HYB 06:00, SC 06:20/06:25, Kazipet 08:03/08:05, Ramagundam 09:28/09:30.

Waitlisted? Check every station and halt this way

1. Direct pairs. On IRCTC / ConfirmTkt / ixigo, search 24 Dec: HYB→NDLS, SC→NDLS, SC→NZM, **KZJ→NDLS, WL→NDLS, BZA→NDLS** (Kazipet, Warangal and Vijayawada have their own quotas). Note AVAILABLE / RAC / WL for every train above.

2. Every halt. If HYB→Delhi is WL, search the same train from HYB to each later halt (Agra Cantt, Gwalior, Jhansi, Bhopal, Itarsi, Nagpur). A shorter ticket can be AVAILABLE when the full one is WL. Ride to Agra, then any Agra→Delhi train or bus (2–3.5 h).

3. Book from the origin. For trains starting elsewhere (22691 from Bengaluru, 12621 from Chennai, 12625 from Thiruvananthapuram), search origin→Delhi and set **Boarding Point** = Secunderabad / Kazipet / Warangal / Vijayawada. You pay the full-route fare but get the origin's quota.

4. Split it. HYB→Nagpur + Nagpur→Delhi (30+ trains a day). Keep 2–3 h between them.

5. Tatkal on 23 Dec (AC 10:00, SL 11:00), 2 PNRs of 3 people each. Premium Tatkal costs more but confirms more often.

6. Tick Vikalp + auto-upgrade and only hold WL if it is under ~WL 20 (3A) / WL 40 (SL) this far out.

6 people = 1 PNR in general quota (max 6 passengers per ticket), but **Tatkal allows only 4 per PNR**, so Tatkal needs 2 bookings from 2 Aadhaar-verified IRCTC accounts at the same minute. Senior citizens get lower berths only in general quota.

Delhi → Kalka → Shimla by toy train (connections and buffers)

If you arrive in Delhi on…	Delhi → Kalka	Kalka → Shimla (toy train)	In Shimla	Buffers	Train cost / person
12723 Telangana · New Delhi ~07:40 (25 Dec)	**12311 Netaji (Kalka Mail)**, Old Delhi ~21:10 → Kalka ~03:00–04:40 (SL)	**52453 Kalka–Shimla Exp** ~06:00–06:20 (2S ≈ ₹65) or 52451 Shivalik Deluxe ~05:20–05:45 (CC ≈ ₹510)	~10:30–11:50 on 26 Dec	~13 h in Delhi = a sightseeing day; 1–3 h in Kalka waiting room	**≈ ₹265** (SL ≈ ₹200 + 2S ₹65)
12621 Tamil Nadu · New Delhi 06:30	**12011 Kalka Shatabdi**, New Delhi 07:40 → Kalka 11:40–11:45 (CC ≈ ₹885 incl. meal)	**52455 Himalayan Queen** 11:55–12:10 → ~17:20 (CC ≈ ₹265; 2S cheaper)	~17:20 on **25 Dec**	70 min at New Delhi (fog risk), ~25 min at Kalka (timed connection)	≈ ₹1,150
22691 Rajdhani · Nizamuddin 05:30	Same 12011 Shatabdi (Nizamuddin → New Delhi 15–20 min by metro/cab)	52455 Himalayan Queen	~17:20 on 25 Dec	~2 h at Delhi	≈ ₹1,150
12625 Kerala · New Delhi 13:30	12311 Kalka Mail ~21:10 (or 12005 Kalka Shatabdi 17:15 → 21:15 + a night in Kalka)	52453 / 52451 next morning	~11:00 on 26 Dec	~7.5 h Delhi	≈ ₹265

Late-December fog regularly delays trains from the south by 1–4 h. If the fast option misses the 07:40 Shatabdi, fall back to the Kalka Mail at night: you lose half a day, not the trip. Book the Shatabdi only after checking the Tamil Nadu Express running status the evening before (Tatkal opens 10:00 on 24 Dec).

Kalka–Shimla toy train timetable

Direction	Train	Departs	Arrives	Classes & approx fare	Notes
Kalka → Shimla	52457 Kalka–Shimla (earliest)	~03:30	~08:55	2S / FC	Listed by some 2026 guides. Verify; may be seasonal
Kalka → Shimla	72451 Rail Motor Car	05:10–05:25	~09:30	≈ ₹320	Glass-roof railcar, 14–18 seats; runs only with enough bookings
Kalka → Shimla	52451 Shivalik Deluxe	05:20–05:45	~10:05–10:40	CC ≈ ₹510 (breakfast incl.)	Fastest regular train
Kalka → Shimla	**52453 Kalka–Shimla Exp**	06:00–06:20	~11:05–11:50	**2S ≈ ₹65**; FC higher	Cheapest reserved seat
Kalka → Shimla	52455 Himalayan Queen	11:55–12:10	~17:20	2S cheap · CC ≈ ₹265 · FC ≈ ₹475	Connects with the 12011 Shatabdi

Timings differ by 10–25 min between sources (travelcoffee 2026, Shimla Tourism, exploreindia, totaltraininfo). Confirm on IRCTC/NTES when you book. Book toy-train seats on IRCTC as soon as the main train is confirmed; 25–26 Dec sells out. Sit on the right side going up for the valley views. The Him Darshan Vistadome (≈ ₹630) runs on some dates.

Fast-track option (Shimla on 25 Dec evening)

Board **12621 Tamil Nadu Express at Kazipet 06:55** (Warangal 06:50, Vijayawada ~04:00) → New Delhi 06:30 → **12011 Kalka Shatabdi 07:40** → Kalka 11:40 → **52455 Himalayan Queen 12:10** → Shimla ~17:20.

Costs ≈ ₹1,150 pp in trains (vs ≈ ₹265) + one more Shimla Airbnb night (≈ ₹1,000–1,500 pp) + getting to Kazipet by 06:30 (night bus ≈ ₹250 or Innova ≈ ₹750 pp). It gains ~17 hours in Shimla. Only 70 min of buffer at Delhi, so book the Shatabdi after checking the train's running status (see note above).

Back to Hyderabad by 3 Jan

Train	Leaves	Reaches Hyderabad	Runs	Fare (SL · 3A)	Fits 'home by 3 Jan'?
12724 Telangana SF Exp	New Delhi **16:00**	Hyderabad Deccan ~17:10 next day	Daily	≈ ₹800 · ≈ ₹2,100	**Leave 2 Jan → home 3 Jan evening**
22692 Nizamuddin–Bengaluru Rajdhani	H. Nizamuddin late evening (≈ 20:30–21:00, verify)	Secunderabad 17:10 arr next day	Daily	3A ≈ ₹3,300–4,100	Leave 2 Jan → home 3 Jan
12722 Dakshin SF Exp	H. Nizamuddin 22:50	Hyderabad Deccan ~03:50 on day 3	Daily	≈ ₹780 · ≈ ₹2,100	Leave 1 Jan night → home 3 Jan 04:00

Hill legs

Leg	Best option	Time	Approx cost / person
Shimla → Manali	HRTC from ISBT Tutikandi (06:00–09:00 departures) via Mandi–Kullu. Innova one-way ≈ ₹9,000–10,000 (÷6 ≈ ₹1,600)	8–10 h	₹550 ordinary · ₹900 deluxe/Volvo
Bhuntar / Manali → Delhi	HRTC ordinary/semi-deluxe or Volvo, 16:00–19:30 departures. Book Manali→Delhi with boarding point Bhuntar	12–14 h	₹950–1,100 ordinary · ₹1,600–2,000 Volvo

Getting around as 6

Option for 6 people	Seats / luggage	Typical hill rate (2025–26)	Per person per day (÷6)	When to choose
Innova Crysta with driver	6–7 + roof carrier	₹4,000–5,500/day (min ~250 km) or ₹16–18/km, + tolls, parking, ₹300–500 driver night	≈ ₹750–1,000	Default for 6 with soft bags
Tempo Traveller 12-seater	Lots of room	₹4,500–7,500/day or ₹18–22/km	≈ ₹850–1,250	Heavy luggage; not allowed on some narrow roads / union areas
2 × Dzire / Etios	4 + 4	₹2,800–3,500/day each	≈ ₹950–1,150	Only if no SUV is available
Local taxi unions (Manali, Pahalgam, Gangtok, Joshimath)	Innova / Tavera / Sumo	Fixed rate cards per circuit	Varies	Mandatory for some circuits (Solang–Sissu, Aru–Betaab, Tsomgo)
Government bus (HRTC / JKSRTC / UTC)	Seats	₹1.5–3 per km	Cheapest	Long point-to-point legs (Shimla→Manali, Delhi→hills)

Day-by-day itinerary

Day 1 · Thu 24 Dec · Hyderabad → on the train

• **06:00 12723 Telangana Express** from Hyderabad Deccan (06:25 Secunderabad, 08:05 Kazipet).

• Carry dinner + next-day breakfast; e-catering delivers at Nagpur, Bhopal, Jhansi.

Stay: Train | **Day spend (per person):** ₹300 food

Day 2 · Fri 25 Dec · Delhi sightseeing day → overnight Kalka Mail

• ~07:40 New Delhi → Metro Yellow Line to Chandni Chowk → leave bags at the **Old Delhi (Delhi Jn) cloak room**.

• **Red Fort** → **Jama Masjid** → **Chandni Chowk** lunch (Paranthe Wali Gali) → **Gurudwara Sis Ganj** → Metro to **Kartavya Path / India Gate** → **Agrasen ki Baoli** → **Connaught Place** → Christmas evening at **Sacred Heart Cathedral**.

• Dinner near Old Delhi, collect bags, board **12311 Kalka Mail ~21:10** (SL). Set an alarm: Kalka is the last stop, ~03:00–04:40.

Stay: Train (SL) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹700 Delhi day + ₹200 train

Day 3 · Sat 26 Dec · Kalka → UNESCO toy train → Shimla

• Wait in the Kalka station waiting hall (1–3 h). Board **52451 Shivalik Deluxe 05:20–05:45** (CC, breakfast) or **52453 Express 06:00–06:20** (2S ≈ ₹65). 96 km, 100+ tunnels, Barog station.

• Shimla ~10:30–11:50. Taxi/porter to the Airbnb. Afternoon: **The Ridge, Christ Church, Mall Road, Scandal Point, Lakkar Bazaar**; **Jakhoo Temple** by ropeway. Evening: Shimla Winter Carnival on the Ridge (usually 25 Dec–1 Jan); ice-skating rink if it's cold enough.

Stay: Airbnb Shimla | **Day spend (per person):** ₹65–510 toy train + ₹400 local + ₹700 food

Day 4 · Sun 27 Dec · Kufri → Fagu → Narkanda → Hatu Peak → Tani Jubbar

• Innova for the day (≈ ₹5,000). Leave by 08:00. **Kufri** (Mahasu pony ride ₹500–800, bargain; keep it short, it's crowded).

• **Narkanda** ski slopes if snow has settled → **Hatu Peak (3,400 m)** wooden temple (walk the last 7 km if it's snow-bound) → **Tani Jubbar lake** (offbeat). Back in Shimla ~19:00.

Stay: Airbnb Shimla | **Day spend (per person):** ₹850 cab share + ₹500 activities + ₹700 food

Day 5 · Mon 28 Dec · Shimla → Manali by HRTC

• Morning HRTC from Tutikandi ISBT via Sundernagar lake, Mandi, Pandoh Dam, Aut tunnel, Kullu → Manali ~17:00. Book seats the evening before.

• Evening: Mall Road, Manu Market, Tibetan monastery.

Stay: Airbnb Old Manali | **Day spend (per person):** ₹550–900 bus + ₹700 food

Day 6 · Tue 29 Dec · Solang Valley → Atal Tunnel → Sissu

• Leave **07:00** in a taxi-union Innova (≈ ₹5,000–6,000 per circuit). Rent suits + gumboots at Palchan (₹300–500).

• Solang: ropeway (₹500–800), skiing lesson (₹1,000–1,500/hr), snow scooter (bargain). **Atal Tunnel (9.02 km)** → **Sissu** frozen waterfall and Chandra river. No permit needed for the tunnel; police stop vehicles at Solang/Dhundi after heavy snow.

Stay: Airbnb Old Manali | **Day spend (per person):** ₹920 cab share + ₹1,500 activities/rent + ₹700 food

Day 7 · Wed 30 Dec · Manali local by scooty + Jogini falls

• 3 scooties (₹500–800/day each). Hadimba Devi, Ghatotkacha shrine, Manu Temple, Old Manali cafés.

• Vashisht hot springs → **Jogini waterfall** trek (~2.5 km each way). Evening: Club House, Mall Road.

Stay: Airbnb Old Manali | **Day spend (per person):** ₹450 scooty + ₹700 food

Day 8 · Thu 31 Dec · Naggar → Jana waterfall → Sethan · NYE

• Innova circuit (≈ ₹3,500): **Naggar Castle** + **Roerich Art Gallery** → **Jana waterfall** village lunch (makki-di-roti, siddu) → **Sethan** snow village and igloo cafés.

• NYE at the Airbnb: bonfire/BBQ (ForestBound has one), or Old Manali cafés with live music (pre-book tables).

Stay: Airbnb Old Manali | **Day spend (per person):** ₹580 cab share + ₹1,000 NYE dinner

Day 9 · Fri 1 Jan · Manali → Kasol, Manikaran → overnight bus from Bhuntar

• Check out by 08:00 (1 Jan jams). Innova Manali → **Kasol** → **Manikaran Sahib** (hot springs, langar) → **Chalal** village walk → drop at **Bhuntar**.

• Overnight bus to Delhi from Bhuntar (18:00–19:30).

Stay: Overnight bus | **Day spend (per person):** ₹750 cab share + ₹1,000–1,800 bus + ₹600 food

Day 10 · Sat 2 Jan · Delhi half-day → train home

• Arrive Majnu ka Tilla / Kashmere Gate ~06:00–08:00. Tibetan breakfast at Majnu ka Tilla → **Humayun's Tomb** → **Lodhi Garden**.

• **16:00 12724 Telangana Express** from New Delhi (backup: 22692 Rajdhani from Nizamuddin late evening).

Stay: Train | **Day spend (per person):** ₹400 Delhi + ₹600 food

Day 11 · Sun 3 Jan · Home

• Hyderabad Deccan ~17:10.

Where you sleep: Airbnb picks for 6 (best-rated and budget)

Nights	Area	Best-rated pick	Budget pick	Est. Dec price, 6 people / night	≈ per person / night
2 (26–27 Dec)	Shimla (Mall/Chhota Shimla side)	**VICTORIAN VILLAS 3BHK**: entire unit, 3 BR, 6 guests, 4.51★ (106 reviews), the most-reviewed 3BR for 6 in Shimla	**Jasm Homes 3BHK** or the 3BR **'Breathtaking Himalayan view'** apartment near Mall Road; Airbnb Shimla floor ≈ ₹949/night for small units	₹6,000–9,000	₹1,000–1,500
4 (28–31 Dec)	Old Manali	**The ForestBound Cottage 3BHK** (BBQ, fireplace): 4.97★, ~70 reviews, Guest favourite, near Hadimba & Old Manali cafés	**Skye Lodges 3BR** (4.85★, 60) · **3 Bedrooms Cottage near Mall Road** (4.88★, 40) · cheapest: Vashisht homestays (e.g. North Himalayan Home Stay; steep last stretch)	₹8,000–14,000	₹1,350–2,350

Listing names, ratings and review counts come from Airbnb search results in Nov 2026. Airbnb blocks automated price checks, so the 'Dec price for 6' column is an **estimate** for an entire 3-bedroom place over the holiday week. Check the live total for your dates.

How to pick the best-rated vs the cheapest on Airbnb

Filters: Guests = 6 · Type of place = **Entire home** · Bedrooms ≥ 3 (or 2 + sofa-beds) · tick **Guest favourite** · toggle **'Display total before taxes'** so the price includes cleaning and service fees.

Best-rated vs cheapest: sort by price after setting the filters, then pick the cheapest listing with ≥ 4.7★ and ≥ 20 reviews. A 5.0★ with 3 reviews is not more reliable than a 4.8★ with 150.

Winter questions to message the host before booking: room heaters (some charge ₹300–500/night per heater), geyser/hot water, power backup, whether a car reaches the door (Old Manali, Vashisht, Jibhi and McLeodganj often have steep stairs), and snow-time access.

NYE rules: many hosts set a 2–3 night minimum for 30 Dec–1 Jan. Book those nights first with flexible or moderate cancellation.

Where Airbnb is thin (Zuluk, Aritar, Rinchenpong, Sari/Chopta, Sangla/Kalpa, Bandipur, Spiti), book homestays by phone or on Booking.com / MakeMyTrip. Usually 3 rooms × ₹1,500–3,000 with meals.

Places covered

Place	Type	Why go	Crowd (late Dec)
Old Delhi, Red Fort, India Gate	Main	Uses the 13-hour Delhi gap	High
Kalka–Shimla toy train	Main (UNESCO)	102 tunnels, Barog, slow scenic ride	High on 25–27 Dec
Shimla Ridge, Mall, Christ Church, Jakhoo	Main	Colonial heart; Winter Carnival	Very high
Kufri	Main	Snow point	Very high
Narkanda + Hatu Peak, Tani Jubbar	Offbeat	Best snow near Shimla; quiet lake	Low
Solang, Atal Tunnel, Sissu	Main	Assured snow, Lahaul views	Very high
Hadimba, Old Manali, Vashisht	Main	Temples, cafés, hot springs	High
Jogini falls, Naggar, Jana, Sethan	Offbeat	Forest trail, old capital, village food, igloo village	Low
Kasol, Manikaran, Chalal	Main + offbeat	Parvati valley	Medium

Bike / scooty rentals

Town	Rates (per day)	Where / how	Notes
Manali	Scooty ₹500–800 · RE Classic 350 ₹1,200–1,500 · Himalayan ₹1,500–2,500	Mall Road, Old Manali, Vashisht shops; Bike Wale Bhaiya, Riderly	Deposit ₹1,000–2,000 + original DL. 3 scooties for 6. No riding beyond Solang on snow/ice
Shimla	Scooty ₹500–800	Near ISBT / Lakkar Bazaar	Mall Road is pedestrian; not needed here
Kasol	Scooty ₹600–900 · RE ₹1,200–1,600	Kasol market	Only if roads are dry

Winter gear: what to buy, what to rent, and where

Gear budget: if you own nothing warm, expect ₹4,000–6,500 one-time purchase (thermals, fleece, gloves, cap, socks, sunglasses) + ₹800–1,500 rentals on the trip. Plan budgets include only the rentals. Six people can share: buy 2 pairs of microspikes and 1 first-aid kit for the group instead of 6.

Item	Need	Buy (Decathlon Hyderabad / local)	Rent (where & rate)	Advice
Thermal inner set (top + bottom) ×2	Must	₹800–1,200 per set (local ₹400–600)	Not rented (hygiene)	Buy. Merino/poly, not cotton
Fleece / sweater (mid layer)	Must	₹600–1,200	—	Buy
Padded / down jacket (−5 to −10 °C)	Must	₹2,500–5,000	Indiahikes rentals ₹55–80/day (ships to you); trek operators ₹100/day; Manali / Gulmarg shops ₹150–300/day	Rent if you won't reuse it: 10 days ≈ ₹600–1,000
One-piece snow suit	Snow points	—	Solang/Palchan, Kufri, Gulmarg, Tsomgo ₹250–500/day (often with gumboots)	Rent on the spot
Gumboots / snow boots	Snow points	—	₹100–200/day (bundled with suit at Solang ₹400–500)	Rent on the spot
Waterproof trekking shoes	Treks	₹2,000–3,500 (Decathlon MH100/MH500)	Trek operators ₹100–150/day	Buy if you'll trek again
Waterproof gloves + woollen inners	Must	₹300–900 + ₹150	—	Buy

Item	Need	Buy (Decathlon Hyderabad / local)	Rent (where & rate)	Advice
Woollen cap / balaclava / neck gaiter	Must	₹200–400 each	—	Buy
Woollen socks (4 pairs)	Must	₹400–600	—	Buy
UV400 sunglasses	Snow	₹300–800	—	Prevents snow-blindness
Microspikes + gaiters	Treks / icy walks	₹1,200–1,800	Chopta/Sari/Sankri/Dharamkot ₹150–250/day; gaiters ₹100/day	Rent

Rental points on this route

Point	What you can rent	Rate
Kufri / Narkanda stalls	Snow suit, gumboots	₹300–500 per set/day
Palchan / Solang	Suit + gumboots + gloves, ski kit	₹300–500; ski + lesson ₹1,000–1,500
Manali Mall Road / Old Manali	Down jackets, boots (cheap to buy at the Tibetan market)	₹150–300/day
Indiahikes rentals (ships to you)	Padded jacket (−10 °C), trek shoes	₹55–100/day

Budget per person (6 people sharing)

Item (per person, 6 sharing)	Shoestring	Recommended	Notes
Train Hyderabad → Delhi (12723)	₹800	₹2,100	SL vs 3A
Delhi day: metro pass, cloak room, Red Fort, food extras	₹400	₹500	
12311 Kalka Mail, Old Delhi → Kalka	₹200	₹200	SL (short overnight run; 3A ≈ +₹400)
Toy train Kalka → Shimla	₹65	₹65	52453 2S (Shivalik Deluxe CC ≈ ₹510 if you prefer)
Shimla taxis to Airbnb, Jakhoo ropeway, local	₹300	₹400	
Kufri–Narkanda–Hatu day (Innova ≈ ₹5,000)	₹850	₹850	÷ 6
Shimla → Manali HRTC	₹550	₹900	Ordinary vs deluxe/Volvo
Manali cabs: Solang–Atal–Sissu, Naggar–Jana–Sethan, Kasol–Bhuntar	₹2,250	₹2,250	≈ ₹13.5k of Innova circuits ÷ 6
3 scooties for the Manali day + fuel	₹450	₹450	2 per scooty
Bhuntar → Delhi bus	₹1,000	₹1,600	HRTC ordinary vs Volvo
Delhi half-day on 2 Jan (metro, Humayun's Tomb)	₹300	₹400	
Train Delhi → Hyderabad (12724)	₹800	₹2,100	SL vs 3A
Airbnb: 2N Shimla + 4N Manali (incl. NYE)	₹7,400	₹10,000	Entire 3-bedroom homes ÷ 6
Food, 10 days	₹5,500	₹6,500	Cook breakfast in the Airbnb
Activities & entries (Solang ropeway/ski, Naggar, skating)	₹1,200	₹2,000	
Winter gear rentals	₹800	₹1,000	
Buffer	₹800	₹1,000	
TOTAL per person	**₹23,665**	**₹32,315**	**Shoestring fits easily. Recommended is above ₹30k mainly because of 3A on the two 25-hour trains and NYE-week Manali Airbnbs; SL on those two trains brings it to ≈ ₹29.7k.**

Bookings to do now (in order)

- **Today:** 12724 return (2 Jan) for 6 on one PNR. Then 12723 onward (24 Dec), then **12311 Kalka Mail (25 Dec)** and the **toy train (26 Dec)**. Both opened in late October, so do it now.
- Airbnb Manali 28 Dec–1 Jan (NYE minimum stays), then Shimla 26–28 Dec.
- Bhuntar/Manali → Delhi bus for 1 Jan (HRTC opens ~30 days ahead). Buy Shimla→Manali HRTC tickets the evening before.

Plan B

- Telangana Express very late (after 19:00 in Delhi)? Still fine for the 21:10 Kalka Mail. If you miss it, take the HRTC overnight Volvo to Shimla from Kashmere Gate (≈ ₹1,000) and skip the toy train.
- Atal Tunnel closed after snow: Solang/Dhundi, or swap with Day 8 (Sethan).
- Hatu snow-bound: walk part-way, or do Chail + Kufri instead.
- 1 Jan jams: skip Kasol and board the bus from Manali directly.

Carry list

- Original photo ID (Aadhaar/DL) + 2 photocopies + **4 passport photos** each (Sikkim/Bhutan permits, J&K checks). **Nepal: passport or voter ID** (Aadhaar is generally not accepted).
- Power bank (cold halves battery life), offline maps, ₹5–8k cash each (ATMs fail in snow areas).
- Group med kit: paracetamol, ORS, cold/cough tablets, band-aids, Vaseline, motion-sickness tablets (hill roads). Diamox only on a doctor's advice.
- Thermos for hot water, quick-dry towel, plastic bags for wet gear, a 3-pin multi-plug for the Airbnb (one socket per room is common).
- Prepaid SIMs from outside J&K don't work in Kashmir. Carry at least 2 postpaid connections in the group (Plan 3).

Safety & buffers

- Roads and snow change by the hour. Check state police traffic updates and ask your host each evening. Emergency: **112**. HP disaster helpline: **1077**.
- No two-wheelers on fresh snow or black ice. Taxis with chains are safer after snowfall.
- Book 30 Dec–1 Jan stays first (NYE rates 2–3×). Prefer flexible cancellation.
- Start the last long leg (hills → Delhi/railhead) by 1 Jan. NYE traffic and snow delay buses 3–8 h.

Sources checked

Reddit and direct page fetches (Airbnb, IRCTC, erail, ConfirmTkt) were blocked from this environment, so everything here comes from web-search results: Airbnb listing snippets, rail timetable aggregators, Team-BHP, Tripoto, travel blogs and local news. Live seat availability and live prices could not be checked; use the checklists above to verify.

— Kalka–Shimla toy train timings/fares: travelcoffee.in 2026 guide, Shimla Tourism, holidify, tusktravel, exploreindia, totaltraininfo
— 12311 Netaji (Kalka Mail): Cleartrip, RailMitra, indiantrain, nativeplanet, totaltraininfo (Old Delhi ~21:10; Kalka 03:00–04:40, sources differ)
— 12011/12005 Kalka Shatabdi: ixigo, Bajaj Finserv, ConfirmTkt, totaltraininfo; 12621/12625/12615 at Kazipet/Warangal/Vijayawada: ConfirmTkt, ixigo, MakeMyTrip, indiarailinfo
— Airbnb listings (ratings/reviews): airbnb.co.in / airbnb.com Shimla, Old Manali, Vashisht pages via search (Nov 2026)
— Innova/Tempo rates: Rajputana Cabs, Triveni Cabs (2026 pages); HRTC fares: mytnstc HRTC table, EaseMyTrip, trekgo
— Atal Tunnel/Sissu winter access: The Tribune, discoverkullumanali.in; Manali rentals & snow gear: vargiskhan, travelcoffee, Tripoto